

Akilan

The Southern Realms

A Fate's Edge Expansion

Preface: Beyond the Dark Continent

When we set out to create the southern realms of Akilan, we sought to avoid a trap all too common in fantasy cartography: the continent rendered as monolith, shadow, or backdrop. "Fantasy Africa" has too often meant a single imagined geography—an undifferentiated mass of "tribes," "savage" wilderness, and static tradition, existing only to provide exotic color or resources for empires elsewhere. It is the "Dark Continent" of Victorian ledgers, empty until filled by foreign ink.

Akilan is not that place.

This expansion presents a continent as fractured, sophisticated, and historically layered as any other region of the known world. The Sahel grasslands of Oshiira are not the jungles of Sekogo; the walking stone cities of Ngomebe share little with the mounted diplomacy of Taharka or the spirit-fleets of Ashaan. The empire of Oshiira operates through a bureaucracy as complex as Ecktoria's, with weighing-houses and canal-mothers whose ledgers track grain shipments with mathematical precision—a nod to the real administrative sophistication of Sahelian states and the ledger traditions of African mercantile societies. The Mason-Kin of Ngomebe partner with Aeler engineers not as "tribesmen receiving foreign aid," but as equals in a millennia-old technological pact that moves mountains on rollers. This is a realm where infrastructure is magic, where the cold war between Oshiira and Kahfagia is fought with tariffs and cipher-books rather than spears, and where the "primitive" accusation is revealed as ignorance of hydrology, metallurgy, and spirit-logic.

We have drawn inspiration from the mythologies of the Sahel, the Horn, the Great Lakes, and the Kongo basin, but we have not assembled a pan-African pantheon. The Patrons here are specific to places and problems: **Mbira**, the spirit of the first weigh-house, reflects the moral weight of trade and measure found in Mande traditions; **Ibeji**, the Twin Stones, honors the Yoruba concept of balanced partnership while serving the mechanical need of the walking cities; **Maji**, the Mother of Wells, speaks to the life-and-death politics of water rights in arid lands. These are not "African gods" in the abstract, but spirits of specific pressures—grain, stone, monsoon, and honey—rooted in the material realities of their regions.

The diversity of Akilan is not cosmetic. The skin tones range from the iron-black of the southern Aeler ranges to the chestnut-brown of the Crimson Valley Lethai-ar, to the bronze and amber of the Fharan-linked Ashaan. But more importantly, the *political* diversity resists the "one Africa" fallacy. Here, empire takes multiple forms: the bureaucratic confederacy of Oshiira, the magocracy of Ashaan, the consensus-based councils of Sekogo, and the ambulatory urbanism of Ngomebe. There are no "tribes" here—only cities, guilds, Mason-Kin Houses, Green Councils, and admiralities, each with their own etiquette, engineering, and historical grievances.

We ask that you approach Akilan not as tourists visiting a "mystical" land, but as travelers entering a web of ledgers, obligations, and cold wars as intricate as any in the north. The Widow's Peace is fragile; the stone cities move for reasons of survival, not whimsy; and the spirits remember debts that no foreigner can easily understand. Bring your dice, but also bring the understanding that here,

as everywhere in Fate's Edge, the mathematics of power are written in salt, grain, and stone—and the ninth measure is always waiting.

Lines and Veils: Navigating Ashaan and Historical Trauma

Content Warning: This expansion includes themes of slavery, spirit-binding, and historical atrocity, particularly regarding Ashaan (the Veiled Throne) and the legacy of the Red Desert wars. While these elements are intended to explore power, trauma, and liberation through the lens of fantasy, they touch on real-world wounds that require care at the table.

Safety Tools Required

- **X-Card (John Stavropoulos):** Any player may tap the X-Card or say "X" to remove content immediately. When invoked regarding Ashaan's spirit-slavery or the treatment of the Breath-less, pause and redirect without question.
- **Lines:** Hard boundaries established in Session Zero. Examples: "No depictions of physical slave markets," "No racialized violence against real-world ethnic groups," "No sexual violence involving captivity."
- **Veils:** Soft boundaries. The existence of spirit-slavery can be acknowledged, but scenes of branding, auction, or physical discipline are "veiled"—described obliquely or occurring off-screen.

Handling Ashaan Specifically Ashaan is designed as a *magocracy recovering from collapse*, not a "nation of slavers." Its use of bound spirits is meant to evoke moral horror—similar to the Lethai-ar's Marks or Oshiira's ledger-obsession—rather than to titillate or reinforce stereotypes of African "dark magic."

- **The Breath-less as Agents:** The freed-spirit agents (spies, guides) are included specifically to center the agency of the enslaved and formerly enslaved. They are not victims to be saved by the players, but complex characters with their own agendas.
- **Avoiding Exploitation:** Do not use Ashaan as a setting for "white savior" narratives. If players intervene in the Spirit Debt or the Brass Gate plotlines, ensure they are supporting local resistance (the Breath-less networks, dissident Veiled Sisters) rather than imposing external morality.
- **Historical Context:** The Red Desert as a "wound" left by war is analogous to real scars of colonialism and the trans-Saharan slave trade. Treat this with the same gravity you would treat the Mistlands' fog-trauma or the Aelerian deep-ledger guilt.

Resources for Guidance If you are unsure how to portray Ashaan or any Akilan culture respectfully, consult:

- "Writing the Other" by Nisi Shawl and Cynthia Ward
- *African History: A Very Short Introduction* by John Parker and Richard Rathbone (for avoiding "timeless Africa" tropes)
- Sensitivity readers for specific cultural elements (recommended for campaigns centering Ashaan or Sekogo)

The Golden Rule Applied: When in doubt, choose the story that serves the dignity of the people at your table. Ashaan's horrors should feel weighty, not entertaining; its spirits should feel wronged, not monstrous; and its liberation—should the players seek it—should be hard-won and complex, not a simple act of charity. The ledger of history is still being written, and your dice are part of the ink.

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I Introduction: The Gulf of Oshiira

South of the Kahfagian straits, beyond the Dolmis Narrows, the Amaranthine opens into a warmer, greener sea. This is the Gulf of Oshiira – a body of water that for centuries has been an Oshiiran lake. The great confederacy of the Sahel grasslands, the Oshiira Empire, controls its trade with an iron grip of logistics, treaties, and the legendary *Widow's Judgment*.

The **Shoreless Bay** marks Oshiira's northern coastline – a broad, shallow sound where grain barges from the Sahel load for Ecktoria, Vhasia, and Silkstrand. Oshiiran wheat feeds half the Amaranthine; its dense canal cities are the breadbasket of the known world. Ecktoria and Oshiira fought four wars to a standstill, though the empire suffered worse. The memory of those wars lingers in every weigh-house and every tariff.

Kahfagia was founded as a check on Ecktorian power – a Oshiiran colony granted independence to harry the empire's western rival. Now it is a pirate-republic, bound to Oshiira by a fragile non-aggression pact and a cold war of spies, tariffs, and proxy raids.

To the east lies Ashaan – a magocracy that is a corpse propped up by the Veiled Sisters. Ashaan invaded Oshiira in the distant past and was broken. The Sisters have no interest in true recovery; they feed on the nation's remaining vitality like a cancer, suppressing dissent with spirit-binding and terror. The people are either complicit, cowed, or secretly opposed. The land itself is cursed: the Red Desert was not always a desert. It is a wound left by Ashaan's own magic, and it continues to spread.

To the south, the highlands of Taharka grow rich on monsoon trade; their horses are legends. Beyond them, the walking stone cities of Ngomebe move across the plateau, their Mason-Kin Houses trading mineral wealth for Aeler engineering. In the deep jungle of Sekogo, the old spirits walk; and in the Crimson Valley, the Lethai-ar guard their borders fiercely, their chestnut-brown skin blending with the red earth.

This expansion provides cultural frameworks, travel decks, and new Patrons for the lands of southern Akilan. Use it to run campaigns of grain politics, slave-liberation, stone-city exploration, and the slow collapse of an empire that has grown too vast for its own ledgers.

2 Peoples of Akilan

2.1 Oshiira – The Ledger Empire

Pillars

Bureaucracy • Grain as power • The Widow's judgment • Maritime tariffs

Appearance

Oshiira is a confederacy of hundreds of tribes and city-states, united by the *Grain Ledger*. The capital, Mbaro, is a city of canals, weigh-houses, and the great Granary Tower. Oshiira is the breadbasket of the Amaranthine; its wheat fills the holds of Ecktorian, Vhasian, and Silk-strand ships. The Shoreless Bay is its northern border, a calm sound dotted with grain-loading piers.

Voice

An Oshiiran scribe speaks with precision and condescension, convinced that the ledger is the only truth. They use words like "bushel-equivalents" and "tare weights" as if they were sacred texts.

Etiquette Hooks

- **Present a stamped receipt** – gain Position +1 in petition scenes.
- **Count aloud** – reduce DV by 1 for Broker tests.

- **Declare your neutrality** – cancel one Oshiiran suspicion SB.
- **Name the Widow first** – never speak of succession before her title.

Strings

Grain Ledger page, Tariff stamp, Barge priority token, Weigh-house seal, Treaty seal (from the cold war pact).

Factions

- *The Vermilion Corps* – internal auditors, feared and hated.
- *The Canal Mothers* – matriarchs who control water-rights.
- *The Salt Syndicate* – merchants who own the desert caravans.
- *The Narrow Captains* – naval officers who itch to provoke Kahfagia.

2.2 Kahfagia – The Flag of Storms

(All original lore from the core game applies. Only the cold war dynamics and voice are added.)

Voice

A Kahfagian speaks with a sharp, musical accent, laced with legalisms learned from Oshiiran clerks and Vilikari smugglers. They use double negatives for emphasis and pepper their speech with maritime slang.

Cold War with Oshiira

The non-aggression pact is a sword of Damocles. The Narrow of Sorrows is the front line: patrol boats shadow each other, customs officials plant spies in weigh-houses, and every captured pirate is a deniable asset. The *Admiralty of Red Shoal* maintains a secret line to the Widow's Vermilion Corps – a back channel for when proxy violence goes too far.

Etiquette Hooks

- **Fly a flag** – never approach a port without a visible banner (Position +1).
- **Name your ransom** – DV –1 for hostage negotiations.
- **Share a cup of salt water** – cancels the first deception SB.
- **Fly the flag of truce** (white with a black crab) – Position +1 when approaching Oshiiran ships; misuse earns a Black Mark.

Strings

Storm-flag, Lantern code, Letter of marque, Cipher book (half-key to Oshiiran dispatches).

2.3 Ashaan – The Veiled Throne

Pillars

Magocracy • Spirit slavery • The Veil • The Knife • Damnation

Appearance

Ashaan is a nation that died long ago. The Veiled Sisters keep its corpse walking through spirit-binding, terror, and the endless consumption of their own people. The capital, Galanina, is a city of black marble and brass cages. The Red Desert, which now covers half the country, was once fertile land; the Sisters' magic leached the life from it. There is no recovery, only a slower dying.

The Ashaani people are not inherently evil, but most are complicit – they must be to survive. A few resist in secret, forming cells of the Breath-less. The Sisters hunt them with spirit-hounds and slave-catchers.

Voice

Ashaani speak with duplicitous elegance. Compliments are also threats; promises always hide a clause. A Veiled Sister's whisper can sound like silk and cut like glass.

Etiquette Hooks

- **Veil your face** – show only your eyes before the Sisters (Position +1).
- **Speak in thirds** – offer two options and a hidden third (GM may grant a clue).
- **Never name the dead** – breaking this earns a geas.

Strings

Spirit-lamp (one-use question), Brass seal (guest status), Veil-clip (speak without being silenced).

Factions

- *The Veiled Sisters* – the ruling wizard-queens, parasites on a corpse.
- *The Esoiti* – magistrates who control every ledger, every court, every gate. To cross an Esoiti is to vanish.
- *The Black Hand* – the secret police, hunters of bodies and spirits. They wear no uniform; they could be your neighbor, your clerk, your spouse.
- *The Breath-less* – a secret network of escaped slaves, forbidden mages, and whisperers of Ikasha's name. They fight to tear down the system from within.

Life Under the Esoiti

Ashaan is not a place of open rebellion. It is a place of whispered warnings, vanished neighbors, and ledgers that rewrite themselves. The Esoiti control everything: who may travel, who may trade, who may live. A merchant's family can be sold for a debt they did not know existed. A child taken for "reevaluation" may return hollow-eyed, if at all. The Black Hand is everywhere and nowhere; to speak Ikasha's name too loudly is to invite a knock at midnight.

"My brother was a factor in the spice market. He argued with an Esoiti about a misweighed sack of cardamom. That night, his name was erased from the rolls. His wife and children were sold to a mine in the Red Desert. I am writing this in a cellar, by the light of a smuggled candle. The Sisters do not know I exist. If you are reading this, I am probably dead. Do not try to find me. Burn this letter. But remember: the Esoiti fear two things – a debt they cannot collect, and a witness who refuses to be silenced." — — A Breath-less agent, intercepted by a Tulkani trader

"The Esoiti came for my father when I was twelve. They accused him of whispering the ninth name. I watched him walk into the Brass Gate and never walk out. My mother told me to smile, to serve tea, to never look at a Sister's eyes. That is survival. But Ikasha taught me that silence is not submission. It is a door. I am learning to open it slowly, one whisper at a time." — — A shopkeeper's daughter, now a scout for the Breath-less

Ikasha's Cult as Active Resistance

Ikasha, She Who Sleeps, is not a patron of open rebellion. Her followers do not march in the streets. They meet in root cellars, in the hollows of abandoned temples, in the pauses between a Black Hand patrol's footsteps. They learn to read ledgers without leaving marks, to speak secrets under the cover of a cough, to move through the city as shadows. Her Rites – Touch the Umbral Veil, Secret Keeper's Burden – become tools of survival. To whisper Ikasha's name is to declare that you still have a self the Sisters have not yet taken.

"They say Ikasha sleeps. I say she is patient. The Sisters have ruled for generations; they believe the Veil is eternal. But the Veil is silk. Silk frays. Ikasha is the moth, and she is teaching us to bite through. One secret at a time. One name at a time."
— — *A Breath-less cell leader, from a letter never sealed*

Adventure Hooks

- A Veiled Sister offers the party a fortune to smuggle a "cured" spirit out of the country – but the spirit is a witness to a massacre.
- A Breath-less cell asks the party to help free a group of children from a Black Hand caravan. The children are destined to become hollowed vessels.
- The Sisters are losing control of a great bound entity. It will break free in three days, and the party must decide whether to help contain it (propping up the corpse) or let it rampage (dooming the innocent as well).
- An Esoiti magistrate offers the party a "clean" identity – a new name, new papers – in exchange for betraying a Breath-less contact. The magistrate's offer is genuine. The price is your soul.

2.4 Ngomebe – The Stone Men

Pillars

Moving cities • Mason-Kin law • Ancestral stone • Anti-magic wards

Appearance

The Ngomebe are dark-skinned; they share ancient ties with the Aeler of the southern ranges. Their cities walk – colossal stone structures on rollers and sledges, dragged by teams of oxen, magic, and Aeler-designed capstans. This partnership is one of the great cross-cultural achievements of the age: Aeler engineers maintain the bearings; Ngomebe masons carve the keystones.

Voice

Ngomebe speak in low, measured tones – the voice of stone. They rarely hurry a sentence.

Etiquette Hooks

- **Touch the city** – place your palm on the outer wall (Position +1).
- **Speak of repair, not conquest** – DV –1 for arbitration.
- **Never carve a name** – breaking this grants the GM 1 SB.

Strings

Keystone charter, Sledge-wax, Stone-song fragment.

2.5 Taharka – The Monsoon Crown

Pillars

Mountain cavalry • Rock-chapels • Spice trade • Neutrality

Wealth

Taharka grows rich on monsoon trade – spices, coffee, and incense that travel east to the Hintara Ocean and west to the Gulf. The kingdom has never been conquered; its passes are a graveyard for Ashaani armies.

Voice

Taharkans speak formally, with elaborate greetings and a deep respect for lineage. They will praise your horse before they praise you.

Etiquette Hooks

- **Remove your shoes** – Position +1 for petitions.
- **Name your horse first** – DV –1 for negotiation.
- **Never refuse a cup** – breaking this earns a 2-segment Penalty clock.

2.6 Sekogo – The Green Council

Pillars

Druidic council • Honey-orchards • Spirit-kin • No slavery

Location

Deep jungle between Oshiira and the southern plateau. The Crimson Valley, home to the Lethai-ar, lies at its eastern edge.

Voice

Sekogo speak in riddles and plant metaphors. They never say "no" directly; they say "the tree does not grow there".

The Three Societies

Beneath the peaceful mask of the Green Council, Sekogo is governed by three interlocking societies, each rooted in the deep folk-horror of the jungle. These are not separate factions but overlapping authorities: a Sekogo nganga often belongs to both the Leopard Society and the Earth Society, and the tension between their roles is where drama lives.

The Leopard Society (Ekpe)

Inspired by the Ekpe lodges of the Cross River, the Leopard Society is the jungle's immune system. Its members are masked hunters who wear the pelts of great cats and believe they can transform into leopards at night to hunt down those who break the deepest taboos: oath-breakers, slavers, and outsiders who take more than they give. They are not evil – they are *necessary*. When a honey-orchard is poisoned or a spirit is bound without consent, the Leopard Society appears at dawn to collect the price.

Etiquette Hooks:

- **Never meet a Leopard's eyes at night** – breaking this may be taken as a challenge (GM gains 2 SB to spend on the hunt).
- **Offer leopard's bane (a rare jungle root) before speaking of debts** – Position +1 in any negotiation with a Society

member.

The Earth Society (Ogboni)

Ogboni elders worship the Earth as the ultimate witness. They hold that the Ukwe (the Speaking Tree) is not merely a spirit but the *covenant stone* between the first people and the land. Their rituals involve keeping the earth's secrets: they bury wrongdoers up to their necks for a moon, they adjudicate land disputes by reading the roots, and they maintain the Calendar of Debt – a sacred list of every unpaid obligation that the jungle remembers.

Etiquette Hooks:

- **Speak while holding a piece of the Ukwe's bark** – you cannot lie; in return, the GM must answer one question about the land's memory truthfully.
- **Never cut a marked tree** – each such tree is a living witness; doing so starts a "Roots Remember" clock [4].

The Nganga of the Green

The nganga are spirit-doctors who work with **minkisi** – power objects inhabited by spirits of the dead, animals, or forces of nature. A nkisi can be a carved figure, a pot, a bundle of leaves and feathers; each is "sealed" with a nail, blade, or mirror. To cast a spell, the nganga hammers the nail into the nkisi, releasing its spirit. The price is that the act creates a *debt* – the nkisi remembers every nail and may one day demand service in return.

Mechanical Hooks:

- A nganga's "spells" are always tied to a specific nkisi. Using the same nkisi more than once per session without renewing its offering advances the "Nkisi Hunger" clock [6]; when it fills, the spirit escapes and wreaks havoc.
- Instead of Obligation to a Patron, a nganga tracks **Debt to the Nkisi**. Mark +1 each time they use a Rite without offering a memory, a name, or a drop of blood.

The Ungwe – The Speaking Tree

The Ukwe is not an oracle; it is a **living ledger**. Its roots extend across Sekogo, and every broken promise, every unpaid tithe, every unburied body stains its leaves. When someone speaks to the Ukwe, it answers – but never with kindness. It may offer a leaf that grants a re-roll ("Ungwe leaf – the tree's blessing (one re-roll on a Survival test)"), but the character who accepts it now owes a *debt to the grove*. The Ukwe's price might be a memory, a year of silence, or the promise to kill someone the tree names. Accepting without understanding the terms is folly.

Mechanical Hooks:

- A character who touches the Ukwe without offering something first must test Spirit + Resolve (DV 4) or forget a random minor memory (GM chooses).
- The Ukwe may speak during scenes of moral crisis. Its advice is always cryptic, never free, and always costs *something* later.

Internal Conflict: Wakers vs. Conservators

The Green Council is split by a fundamental argument:

- **Conservators** believe the jungle must be protected from outsiders and from itself. They enforce the old pacts, maintain the honey-tithe, and keep the Leopard Society on a short leash.
- **Waker radicals** argue that the jungle has grown sluggish, that the old spirits are sleeping too deeply. They want to "wake" the forest – to encourage fever-mists, aggressive thorn-spirits, and even the Leopard Society's more lethal practices. Some Wakers have already poisoned foreign caravans and collapsed mines that offended the land.

The Council's fragile peace is tested every season. A Conservator might ask the party to hunt a Waker who has gone too far; a Waker might recruit the party to assassinate a Conservator who stands in the way of "true balance." Neither side is clearly right – each has blood on its hands.

Folk-Horror Twists for the GM

- A Leopard Society member who helps the party may later demand they participate in a "hunt." Refusal earns a Leopard's Mark – a curse that makes the jungle hostile.
- A nkisi that the party carries begins whispering at night. It offers power, but each use erodes the holder's connection to their own memories: once per scene, the GM may ask "What

did the nkisi take?” and the player must name a minor fact they forget.

- The Ukwe begins asking for names – not of enemies, but of loved ones. If the party refuses, the tree closes its paths. If they comply, they discover the name was a witness to an old crime, and now the debt has transferred to them.

New Strings (Sekogo)

- **Leopard’s Favor** – once, you may call on the Leopard Society for a hunt (they will track one person through any terrain, but you owe them a future hunt).
- **Ungwe Debt** – the tree remembers you; once per session, you may reroll a failed Survival or Nature roll, but the GM gains 1 SB to spend on a jungle complication.
- **Nkisi Shard** – a broken power-object; once, you may add +1 Effect to a magical working, but the shard shatters and costs 1 Corruption.

2.7 Lethai-ar of the Crimson Valley

Appearance

The Lethai-ar in Akilan are chestnut-brown (darker than the maple-skinned northern elves). They guard the Crimson Valley – a jungle rift between Sekogo and Oshiira – with fierce neutrality. Their silk bridges

span the red canyons; their web-law keeps both empires from using the valley as a shortcut to war.

Like their northern kin, the Lethai-ar are descended from spirit-peoples who once walked the Ways Between. In Akilan, this ancestry is more present: many Lethai-ar can name the specific mountain, river, or grove where their ancestor left the spirit world to become mortal. They are, in a real sense, *adopted children of the old powers* – not fallen, but *chosen* to carry memory.

Relationships

They trade with Sekogo druids (honey for poison) and with Ngomebe (stone-song for silk). Oshiira respects their borders because any invasion would bleed through the valley.

Marks

Their skin-tattoos (Marks) are woven with red ochre and jungle sap; context keys involve the phases of the crimson moon. A Lethai-ar's Mark is also a *debt token* – each line records a promise witnessed. When a Lethai-ar dies, their Marks are cut from the skin and buried at the Ukwe's roots, so the tree may remember what they owed.

2.8 Aeler of the Southern Ranges

Appearance

The Aeler of Akilan are black-skinned, their hair often dusted with iron ore. They live in the mountain ranges south of Oshiira, adjacent

to Ngomebe. Their partnership with the Stone Men is legendary: Aeler vent-priors design the bearing systems for the walking cities; Ngomebe masons provide the keystone hearts. The two peoples intermarry in the border holds, and their guilds share a single underworld.

Culture

Same as northern Aeler (deep accounting, breath-bonds, keystone rights), but with a southern accent: the "oven" is a furnace for smelting; the "grain surety" is paid in iron blooms.

2.9 Amaria – The Iron Shore

Pillars

Ecktorian colony • Iron mines • Legal hybrid • Isolated

Location

A small peninsula on the Gulf's west coast, squeezed between Kahfagia and Oshiira. It remains neutral by paying tribute to both.

Etiquette Hooks

- **Produce a writ** – DV –1 for entry.
- **Speak Utaran** – Position +1 for official business.
- **Pay in silver** – breaking this marks 1 segment on a Colonial Hubris clock.

3 Travel Decks for Akilan

Use the standard Fate's Edge travel procedure (draw one card from each suit: Spade=place, Heart=actor, Club=pressure, Diamond=leverage). Highest rank sets clock size (4/6/8/10). Each deck below replaces the regional decks from the core travel guide for Akilan.

3.1 Oshiira (Sahel Grasslands)

Spades – Places	
2–5	Mudflat weigh-station; grain sacks piled under reed awnings.
6–10	Granary tower with a cracked ledger door.
J–K	Canal junction; three barges, one pilot with a sealed writ.
A	The Widow’s weigh-house – bronze scales, silent clerks.
Hearts – People	
2–5	Grain inspector with a brass stamp.
6–10	Canal Mother bargaining over water rights.
J–K	Vermilion Corps auditor, ink on fingers.
A	A Narrow Captain nursing a grudge against Kahfagia.
Clubs – Complications	
2–5	Dust from the Ashaani desert coats the grain (Inspector halts the caravan).
6–10	Locust swarm (Supply –1).
J–K	Cold war provocation – a Kahfagian “pirate” is sighted.
A	The Widow’s health fails; succession rumors spike.
Diamonds – Leverage	
2–5	Receipt for stolen grain – blackmail material.
6–10	Barge priority token – skip

3.2 Ashaan (Red Desert)

Spades – Places	
2–5	Salt pan with a broken spirit-cage.
6–10	Black marble temple; steps stained red.
J–K	The Brass Gate – a fortified strait with spirit-buoys.
A	A Veiled Sister’s sanctum, entrance hidden by a mirage.
Hearts – People	
2–5	Slave-hunter (Black Hand) with a branding iron.
6–10	Breath-less agent (freed slave, now spy).
J–K	A Veiled Sister testing the party’s honesty.
A	An Ashaani magician who offers dangerous knowledge.
Clubs – Complications	
2–5	Spirit-dust storm (Navigation DV +I, mark Fatigue).
6–10	Brass Gate closed for ”inspection” – delay 2 segments.
J–K	A bound spirit breaks free; attacks the nearest living thing.
A	The Veil fails – spirit-visions haunt all present.
Diamonds – Leverage	
2–5	A slave’s true name – can be used to free them (or bind them further).

3.3 Ngomebe (Stone Lands)

Spades – Places	
2–5	A city on the move – rollers groan, oxen low.
6–10	Abandoned quarry; stone-song echoes.
J–K	Mason-Kin hall, walls carved with lineage.
A	The edge of a city’s path – the stone is warm.
Hearts – People	
2–5	Stone-cutter whose city has left them behind.
6–10	Mason-Kin elder, grey with granite dust.
J–K	Root-binder heretic, planting acorns in the rollers.
A	Aeler engineer: grease-stained, carrying a level.
Clubs – Complications	
2–5	A keystone cracks – the city stops.
6–10	Root-binder sabotage – a wheel jams.
J–K	Mason-Kin feud over the next migration route.
A	Earth tremor (all actions Desperate for a scene).
Diamonds – Leverage	
2–5	Keystone charter – right to dwell in a city for a season.
6–10	Sledge-wax – greases negotiation with the Mason-Kin.

3.4 Sekogo Crimson Valley

Spades – Places	
2–5	Honey-orchard; the trees hum.
6–10	A severed nkisi hangs from a branch.
J–K	Druid circle; stones covered in moss. A leopard skull sits at the center.
A	A Lethai-ar silk bridge spanning a crimson gorge. Below, the Ukwe’s roots clutch the water.
	The Ungwe – a tree so old it speaks. Its bark is covered in carved names, each one a debt.
Hearts – People	
2–5	Sekogo honey-gatherer with a fruit offering. She wears a leopard claw around her neck.
6–10	Green Council druid carrying a thorn-staff. Her eyes are milky; she is blind to the living but sees debts.
J–K	Waker radical plotting to awaken the jungle. He carries a bag of fever-mist spores.
A	Lethai-ar silk-warden, masked and quiet. His mask is painted with the Ukwe’s roots.
Clubs – Complications	
2–5	A thorn-spirit blocks the path – must offer honey or fight. The spirit demands a name.

3.5 Taharka (Highlands)

Spades – Places	
2–5	Terraced farm; coffee shrubs on every step.
6–10	Rock-chapel; the walls drip condensation.
J–K	High pass; snow even in summer.
A	The King's stable – horses with brass halter.
Hearts – People	
2–5	Horse trader with a copper bell.
6–10	Ridge-Watcher captain, bow over shoulder.
J–K	Spice House merchant, robes smelling of cardamom.
A	The Crown Council's envoy – careful, neutral.
Clubs – Complications	
2–5	A landslide blocks the pass (delay 2 segments).
6–10	Ashaani raiders disguised as merchants.
J–K	Horse sickness – all mounts lose 1 Speed.
A	The King is assassinated; pass closes to all foreign traffic.
Diamonds – Leverage	
2–5	Horse-bond – a foal promised (future String).
6–10	Pass-stone – crossing a high pass at half toll.
J–K	Confederate alliance – all

3.6 Kahfagia (Cold War Theater)

Use the core Kahfagia travel deck; add these cold-war specific entries:

Spades (Place) – The Narrow of Sorrows (any rank): A reef-laced channel where Oshiiran and Kahfagian warships watch each other across a cannon's breadth.

Hearts (Person) – The Narrow Captain (any rank): Oshiiran naval officer who chafes at the pact; may offer a deal to provoke an incident.

Clubs (Complication) – Flag of Truce Misused (any rank): A Kahfagian privateer flies the white crab flag to ambush an Oshiiran grain barge. The party is caught in the middle.

Diamonds (Leverage) – Cipher Book (any rank): Half-key to intercepted Oshiiran dispatches; one use to learn a secret.

4 Patrons of Akilan

These twelve Patrons are drawn from the cultures, landscapes, and conflicts of Akilan. Each follows the standard Fate's Edge Patron format: Lore, Favored Deeds, Taboos, and Rites. Obligation capacity = Spirit + Presence.

4.1 Mbira – The First Weigh

Domain

Grain, census, justice, the unalterable ledger.

Lore

Mbira is the spirit of the first weigh-house, present when the first bushel of grain was measured against the first bronze weight. She does not forgive arithmetic errors.

Favored Deeds

Correcting a false ledger, exposing a grain thief, paying a debt in full with interest.

Taboos

Burning a receipt, forgiving a debt without witness, using false weights.

Low Rite – Stamp of Truth (4 XP)

Touch a document; for one scene, any forgery attempted on it becomes obvious to you. Additionally, you may detect if a document has been magically altered. (Mark +1 Obligation)

Standard Rite – Weigh the Heart (8 XP)

Target must confess a minor financial crime or suffer –1 die to all social rolls until they do. (Mark +2 Obligation)

High Rite – The Ledger of Souls (14 XP)

For one hour, you can see the "value" of every person you meet – their debts, their credits, their unfulfilled contracts. (Mark +3 Obligation)

4.2 Tano – The Stone that Walks**Domain**

Migration, keystones, the pact between earth and engineering.

Lore

Tano is a spirit of the moving cities – the consciousness that allows a stone to roll without cracking.

Favored Deeds

Repairing a city's keystone, clearing a migration route, settling a Mason-Kin dispute.

Taboos

Letting a city stop without cause, using a chisel on living rock, harming an ox that pulls a city.

Low Rite – Song of the Keystone (4 XP)

Sing a low note; one stone door or bridge opens or closes. (Mark +1 Obligation)

Standard Rite – Bearings of Peace (8 XP)

For one leg, your mount or wagon ignores the first difficult terrain penalty. (Mark +2 Obligation)

High Rite – Tano's Path (14 XP)

You may move a walking city up to 1 mile in a single night – but you must sacrifice an object of personal value to the rollers. (Mark +3 Obligation)

4.3 Nkosi – The Lion of the Sahel**Domain**

Grasslands, courage, the pride of the hunt.

Lore

Nkosi is a great lion spirit who tests the strong and eats the weak. He respects only those who face him standing.

Favored Deeds

Defending the helpless, winning a duel against a stronger foe, sparing an enemy who surrenders.

Taboos

Ambushing from behind, harming a cub, breaking a sworn oath of hospitality.

Low Rite – Mane of Fire (4 XP)

Your hair glows with golden light; +1 die to Intimidation for one scene. (Mark +1 Obligation)

Standard Rite – Roar of the Pride (8 XP)

All allies within Near range gain +1 die to resist fear for one scene. (Mark +2 Obligation)

High Rite – Nkosi's Judgment (14 XP)

Challenge one opponent to a duel. If you win, they must perform one service for you (no suicide). If you lose, you owe them a season of fealty. (Mark +3 Obligation)

4.4 Maji – The Mother of Wells

Domain

Water, wells, the hollow spaces in stone.

Lore

Maji is the spirit of every spring, cistern, and rain-catch. She is generous but jealous: if you waste her gift, she will dry your throat.

Favored Deeds

Digging a new well, sharing water with the thirsty, cleaning a cistern.

Taboos

Polluting a spring, hoarding water during a drought, lying near a well.

Low Rite – Cup of Mercy (4 XP)

Pour water on dry ground; for one scene, you know the direction to the nearest clean water. (Mark +1 Obligation)

Standard Rite – Seal the Cistern (8 XP)

Touch a water source; it becomes undrinkable to all but you and your allies for one day. (Mark +2 Obligation)

High Rite – Maji's Tears (14 XP)

Cause a short rain over a 1-mile area. Crops grow, but the rain also exposes any spirit within the area. (Mark +3 Obligation)

4.5 Kalia – The Veiled Sister

Domain

Secrets, spirit-binding, the hidden knife.

Lore

Kalia is a rogue Veiled Sister who ascended to patronship by binding her own shadow. She teaches that every truth has a price and that the best secrets are the ones you never speak. Her followers are spies, assassins, and liberators of slaves.

Favored Deeds

Freeing a spirit from bondage, revealing a tyrant's secret, wearing a veil in a foreign court.

Taboos

Breaking a vow of silence, binding a child's spirit, speaking your true name to an enemy.

Low Rite – Knife of Silence (4 XP)

For one scene, your footsteps make no sound. (Mark +1 Obligation)

Standard Rite – Unbind (8 XP)

Release a bound spirit from an object; the spirit owes you one question. The spirit may not lie, though it may answer cryptically. (Mark +2 Obligation)

High Rite – Kalia's Mask (14 XP)

For one day, you may appear as any person you have touched. The illusion breaks if you draw blood. (Mark +3 Obligation)

4.6 Sefu – The Forge of Stone**Domain**

Iron, smithing, the fire under the plateau.

Lore

Sefu is a spirit of the great furnaces where Ngomebe and Aeler smelt their ore together. He is patient, hot, and unforgiving of impurities.

Favored Deeds

Forging a weapon for a worthy cause, returning a stolen ingot, teaching a child to strike true.

Taboos

Selling flawed iron, using a forge for murder, allowing a fire to go unattended.

Low Rite – Steady Hand (4 XP)

For one scene, your Craft rolls gain +1 die. (Mark +1 Obligation)

Standard Rite – Sefu’s Seal (8 XP)

Touch a metal object; for one day, it cannot be melted or reshaped.
(Mark +2 Obligation)

High Rite – The Living Anvil (14 XP)

You may forge a single weapon that ignores mundane armor for one battle. The ritual requires rare materials (iron from a fallen star, charcoal from the Ukwe, blood from the smith’s own hand). At the end of the battle, the weapon crumbles. (Mark +3 Obligation)

4.7 Zuri – The Honey-Mother**Domain**

Bees, sweetness, the pact of pollination.

Lore

Zuri is a spirit of the Sekogo groves, who taught the druids how to speak to bees. She is kind, but she remembers every sting.

Favored Deeds

Planting a flowering tree, rescuing a swarm, sharing honey with the hungry.

Taboos

Burning a hive, using smoke to harvest, killing a bee without need.

Low Rite – Sweet Tongue (4 XP)

For one scene, your Sway rolls gain +1 die. (Mark +1 Obligation)

Standard Rite – Zuri's Blessing (8 XP)

Touch a wound; it heals 1 Harm, but the patient craves honey for a day. (Mark +2 Obligation)

High Rite – The Swarm's Voice (14 XP)

For one hour, you may command an ordinary swarm of bees (treat as Cap 3 ally). (Mark +3 Obligation)

4.8 Kito – The Rider of the Monsoon**Domain**

Horses, speed, the wind that brings rain.

Lore

Kito is a spirit of Taharkan horsemanship, born from the first mare that outran the monsoon. He is proud, fleet, and impatient with slow talk.

Favored Deeds

Racing fairly, cooling a lathered horse, sharing a pass with a stranger.

Taboos

Whipping a tired horse, selling a sick animal as healthy, blocking a mountain road.

Low Rite – Kito's Breath (4 XP)

Your mount gains +1 Speed for one leg. (Mark +1 Obligation)

Standard Rite – The Rider's Bond (8 XP)

For one scene, you and your mount share senses. (Mark +2 Obligation)

High Rite – Monsoon Hoof (14 XP)

You may ride through a sandstorm without penalty for one scene. (Mark +3 Obligation)

4.9 Ayo – The Drummer of the Gulf

Domain

Tides, storms, the rhythm of wind and wave.

Lore

Ayo is a spirit of the Gulf of Oshiira, who drums the waves against the shore. She is wild and generous to sailors who respect her beat.

Favored Deeds

Saving a drowning sailor, dancing during a storm, leaving a coin on the tide line.

Taboos

Cutting a ship's drum, silencing a bell during a squall, fishing during a red tide.

Low Rite – Drumbeat of Calm (4 XP)

For one scene, your ship ignores the first weather penalty. (Mark +1 Obligation)

Standard Rite – Call the Tide (8 XP)

Raise or lower the tide in a small bay by one foot. (Mark +2 Obligation)

High Rite – Ayo's Dance (14 XP)

Summon a brief squall that scatters enemy ships. (Mark +3 Obligation)

4.10 Nuru – The Light of the Weigh-house**Domain**

Lamps, ledgers, the clarity of numbers.

Lore

Nuru is a spirit of Oshiiran bureaucracy, who kindled the first lamp in the Granary Tower. He is precise, unforgiving, and utterly neutral.

Favored Deeds

Reconciling a disputed account, illuminating a dark archive, catching a counterfeiter.

Taboos

Smudging a stamp, burning a receipt, lying under a lantern.

Low Rite – Nuru's Candle (4 XP)

Light a small flame; for one scene, you can see invisible ink. (Mark +1 Obligation)

Standard Rite – The Auditing Gaze (8 XP)

For one scene, you can detect when someone is lying about numbers (weights, measures, counts). (Mark +2 Obligation)

High Rite – The Ledger of Light (14 XP)

Touch a document; it becomes impossible to alter by any means for one year. (Mark +3 Obligation)

4.II Oya – The Wind of the Sahel

Domain

Dust, change, the breath that clears the old.

Lore

Oya is a spirit of the harmattan – the dry wind that sweeps the grasslands, carrying red dust from Ashaan. She destroys the weak and cleanses the strong.

Favored Deeds

Burning a corrupt contract, opening a sealed door, revealing a hidden chamber.

Taboos

Building a wall that blocks the wind, imprisoning a truth-teller, hoarding grain during a drought.

Low Rite – Oya's Breath (4 XP)

For one scene, you may extinguish any non-magical fire. (Mark +1 Obligation)

Standard Rite – Dust Mask (8 XP)

For one scene, you are immune to the effects of sandstorms. (Mark +2 Obligation)

High Rite – The Cleansing Wind (14 XP)

Summon a dust storm that lasts one hour. All actions within are Desperate. (Mark +3 Obligation)

4.12 Ibeji – The Twin Stones**Domain**

Partnership, balance, the union of Aeler and Ngomebe.

Lore

Ibeji are twin spirits – one of stone, one of gear – who dance together to keep the walking cities alive. They teach that no craft is complete without another.

Favored Deeds

Building a bridge together, sharing credit for a repair, saving a partner's life.

Taboos

Taking sole credit, letting a partner fail without help, breaking a twin-keystone.

Low Rite – Balanced Weight (4 XP)

For one scene, you and an ally gain +1 die to any roll made to assist each other. (Mark +1 Obligation)

Standard Rite – Ibeji's Seal (8 XP)

Touch two objects; for one day, they cannot be separated by less than magical force. (Mark +2 Obligation)

High Rite – The Dance of Stone (14 XP)

You and an ally may move a stone city's roller 1 mile without oxen – but you both mark 2 Fatigue. (Mark +3 Obligation)

5 Campaign Fronts & Clocks

Use these global clocks for an Akilan campaign.

Fac- tion	Influence	Stability	Crisis	Goal
Os- hi- ira Em- pire Ngomebe Ma- son-Kin	6 4	8 6	4 (Grain riots) 4 (City drift)	Main- tain the Widow's Peace Keep the cities mov- ing south Pre- serve the corpse of the na- tion Pro- tect the groves
Ashaan Magoc- racy	5	3	8 (Spirit revolt)	Main- tain the Widow's Peace Keep the cities mov- ing south Pre- serve the corpse of the na- tion Pro- tect the groves
Sekogo Green Coun- cil Taharka Crown	4 5	5 7	3 (Waker violence) 4 (Pass closure)	Main- tain the Widow's Peace Keep the cities mov- ing south Pre- serve the corpse of the na- tion Pro- tect the groves
Kahfa- gian Ad-	6	4	8 (Widow's intervention)	Main- tain the Widow's Peace Keep the cities mov- ing south Pre- serve the corpse of the na- tion Pro- tect the groves

Front Clocks (campaign level):

- *The Widow's Health* [8] – when filled, the empress dies; succession crisis triggers a region-wide war.
- *The Spirit Debt* [6] – Ashaan's bound spirits grow restless; when filled, a mass haunting destabilises the Veil.
- *The Stone Pact* [6] – Oshiira and Ngomebe negotiate a permanent border; when filled, either peace or war.
- *Cold War Pressure* [6] – ticks when the party raids an Oshiiran barge for Kahfagia, or smuggles grain past a Kahfagian blockade. At 2: sanctions (goods cost +1). At 4: a naval skirmish. At 6: the pact frays; open war becomes possible.

6 Adventure Seeds

Ten drop-in scenarios for Akilan:

1. **The Widow's Ledger:** A page from the Grain Ledger is stolen. Without it, a tribe cannot prove its harvest. Find the forger before the tribe starves.

2. **The City That Stopped:** A Ngomebe city has run aground. The Mason-Kin blame a Root-binder. The party must find the saboteur – or push the city themselves.

3. **The Spirit Cargo:** The party is hired to escort a sealed brass coffin from Ashaan to Oshiira. Inside is a bound spirit – and a rival faction wants to free it.

4. **The Honey Tithe:** A Sekogo grove demands tribute before letting a caravan pass. The tribute is a story. The party must tell a tale that satisfies the spirits.

5. **The Coffee Challenge:** A Taharkan prince offers the party a fortune to race his horse against an Oshiiran steed. The loser's kingdom forfeits a pass.

6. **The Storm-Flag Feud:** Two Kahfagian captains claim the same flag. The Admiralty demands the party referee a duel – to the first blood or the first confession.

7. **The Mine Strike:** Amarian miners barricade the shaft. The Censorate wants them removed. The party must negotiate – or break the barricade without causing a massacre.

8. **The Brass Gate:** An Ashaani magician has bribed the Oshiiran admiral of the straits. The party must expose the bribe before the Veiled Sisters sail through.

9. **The Walking Tree:** A Sekogo druid claims one of the Ngomebe cities crushed a sacred grove. The Mason-Kin deny it. The party must survey the path – and find a witness that cannot lie.

10. **The Widow's Heir:** The empress is dying. Her four children vie for the throne. The party is offered a barony to escort the heir of their choice to Mbaro. But each heir has a secret: one is a half-breed, one is a spirit, one is a puppet, and one is already dead.

7 GM Toolkit

7.1 Sahel Weather & Hazards (d12)

1. Khamsin – dust obscures; ranged attacks –1 die.
2. Heat shimmer – mirages; Navigation DV +1.
3. Sudden flood – dry wadi becomes a river; lose 1 Supply.
4. Locust swarm – eat exposed grain; advance the Grain Ledger clock.
5. Desert night – cold enough to freeze water; mark 1 Fatigue if unsheltered.
6. Red dust – Ashaani sand carried eastward; social rolls –1 die; on a 1, a minor spirit manifests.
7. Sand geyser – pillar of sand; test Body + Athletics or be separated from the caravan.
8. Calm – no event; reroll.
9. Elephant stampede – test Stealth or take Harm 1 (trampling).
10. Grass fire – spread of flames; all actions Desperate until fire is passed.
11. Rain of frogs – omen; next scene begins with a 4-clock "Sign from Maji".

12. Widow's Omen – distant thunder; the party dreams of ledgers and death.

7.2 Random Oshiiran Encounters (d12)

1. Grain inspector demanding a bribe.
2. Vermilion Corps agent auditing a caravan.
3. Canal Mother seeking a new alliance.
4. Salt syndicate offering a loan (with interest).
5. Tribal chief asking for a witness to a feud.
6. Escaped Ashaani spirit, lost and confused.
7. Ngomebe stone-cutter who has lost his city.
8. Kahfagian pirate selling "insurance".
9. Amarian miner with a silver nugget and a story.
10. Taharkan horse-trader with a mount that talks.
11. Sekogo druid asking for help against a Waker.
12. A Veiled Sister in disguise, testing the party's honesty.

7.3 Integration with Existing Expansions

- **Political Intrigue:** Oshiiran factions use Influence/Stability/Exposure. The Widow's death is a Crisis trigger.

- **Caravans:** Sahel legs require Water-Wise and Grain-Ledger tags. New Intent: Tribute.
- **Amaranthine Sea:** The Gulf is a new theater; add Reef-Singers and Monsoon Front.
- **Witches of Fate's Edge:** Sekogo druids use Echo/Veil/Flow. The Veiled Sisters are a variant of the Cord (spirit-binding is memory-weaving inverted).
- **Horror Campaigns:** Ashaan is a Dread Clock generator. Use the Reality Fracture track for the Veil.
- **Shadows & Steel:** Amaria and Kahfagia are criminal havens. Use Crew Heat and Informant Webs.
- **Dragon's Lair:** The walking cities of Ngomebe can be treated as lairs; the city itself is a boss.
- **Kon"reh:** The Oshiiran school (Canray) is "Logistics Control". Ashaani play "Veil & Knife". Sekogo refuse to play.

8 Colophon

Akilan is not a dark continent. It is a web of empires, spirits, and stone. The Widow's Peace is a bargain, not a blessing. The cities move because staying still is death. And the spirits, the stones, and the trees all have opinions – if you know how to ask.

When the monsoon turns and the grain ships race the storms, you will see the ledger's true weight. It is not written in ink. It is written in the bones of those who could not pay.

— Dusana of the Raven Road, at the weigh-house of Mbaro, after a cup of coffee and a handful of salt.